

a shift from free entry to ticketed matches, and a noticeable rise in playing standards.

But has it lived up to expectations?

Bridging the gap

The 2025 WPL season was the most competitive yet, thanks in no small part to Gujarat Giants. After two wooden spoon finishes, the team finally found its spark midway through the season, storming into the playoffs with a string of dominant performances.

A new coaching staff, a change in captaincy, and a strategic focus on nurturing Indian talent played a big role in this turnaround. Across seasons two and three, the franchise invested in domestic players, tracking progress through camps and giving them opportunities.

This is the same team that, in its debut season, made headlines for all the wrong reasons — most notably, the puzzling decision to release Deandra Dottin before the tournament even began. But in 2025, Gujarat made a different kind of statement by backing an uncapped Indian player, Kashvee Gautam, despite her injury concerns. The pace-bowling all-rounder, once sidelined by a foot fracture, emerged as one of the team's standout performers.

"We've tried to strike a balance between preparing players for the pressures of the big stage while also keeping their heads pressure-free," Giants head coach Michael Klinger told *Sportstar*. "Cricket, domestic or otherwise, is largely result-oriented, and it's important to shield players from that pressure sometimes."

The Giants also made some bold selection calls. A senior Indian spinner — the team's former vice-captain, Sneha Rana — was left out of the XI due to poor form. South African batter Laura Wolvaardt lost her opening slot after three underwhelming outings, making way for the in-form Beth Mooney.

More importantly, Gujarat put faith in its Indian bowling unit. While overseas stars like Dottin, Mooney, Phoebe Litchfield, Danielle Gibson,

and Ashleigh Gardner carried the batting, the bowling workload fell largely on Indian players. Kashvee, Priya Mishra, Meghna Singh, and Tanuja Kanwar and others bowled over 106 overs combined — nearly twice as many as the overseas players.

If Royal Challengers Bengaluru's 2024 title-winning run was magical, Gujarat's resurgence in 2025 was nothing less. But its campaign ended in heartbreak, falling to eventual champion Mumbai Indians in the Eliminator.

That match summed up some of the biggest talking points in the WPL:

Fielding remains a weak link — it put the team on the back foot before it had even batted.

Mumbai's international stars dominated — overseas firepower once again made the difference.

Handling pressure is still a challenge — when the stakes were highest, Gujarat faltered.

An object of envy

With Nat Sciver-Brunt, Hayley Matthews, and Amelia Kerr, Mumbai Indians had the dream trio of all-rounders — each hitting top form at different points in the season.

At the halfway mark, Mumbai's inconsistency had team owners on edge. If RCB had managed to break out of its struggles, the title race might have ended differently.

But when it mattered most, Sciver-Brunt turned unstoppable. After enduring heartbreak with England at the T20 World Cup and the Ashes, she delivered a season for the ages in Mumbai colours — 500 runs, 12 wickets, and an infuriating ability to just not get out. She became the first player to cross 1,000 WPL runs, leading Mumbai's charge to the title.

Yet, Mumbai's strength wasn't built on one player. Matthews and Kerr controlled the spin department, Shabnim Ismail brought sheer pace, and Harmanpreet Kaur thrived with the bat. The result? A near-unbeatable side.

What truly set it apart, though, was its one standout Indian talent — Emerging Player of the Season,



Amanjot Kaur.

During the Bengaluru leg, at a packed M. Chinnaswamy Stadium, Harmanpreet backed her in a crunch moment. "If you stay out there, you'll be able to do it easily," she told Amanjot. The young all-rounder responded with confidence: "I'll do it for you, don't worry." She delivered exactly as promised.

Amanjot's reliability gave Harmanpreet the freedom to attack. With the ball, she chipped in with five wickets across 17 overs at a respectable economy of 7.88. But her biggest impact came in the field — diving, stopping, and saving runs in crucial moments.

Harmanpreet credited the league's growing depth for the tight competition this season. "In the first season, I think we missed out on a lot of good cricketers. We are playing elite cricket, and the games are tough. This time, all franchises have